

After your frenectomy

RECOVERY GUIDE · LIP, TONGUE, OR CHEEK TIE RELEASE

Keep this guide handy
Call our office with any questions

A small band of tissue (the frenum) was released to improve movement of your lip, tongue, or cheek. The area is small, and most patients heal quickly — usually within 1–2 weeks. The most important thing for a good result is doing gentle stretches so the tissue doesn't reattach as it heals.

TODAY	DAYS 1–3	DAYS 4–14	WEEKS 3–6
Mild soreness. Cool, soft foods. Begin stretches as instructed.	Yellow/white patch appears at the site. Continue stretches.	Soreness fades. Patch slowly goes away. Keep stretching.	Tissue fully remodels. Full range of motion.

Stretches are the key to a good result

As the area heals, the tissue naturally wants to reconnect — which can undo the release. **Gentle stretches several times a day keep the area open while it remodels.** You'll start these either the day of surgery or the day after, depending on what we told you at your visit.

How often: 4–6 times a day for the first 2 weeks, then taper over weeks 3–4. **How long:** Hold each stretch for 1–2 seconds. A short "ouch" moment is okay — sustained pain is not. Do not skip, even if it feels sore.

1 How to do the stretches

We'll show you the specific technique for your type of release. The general idea is gentle, consistent movement to keep the wound from reattaching.

UPPER LIP TIE

- Use a clean finger under the upper lip
- Gently lift the lip straight up toward the nose
- Hold for 1–2 seconds, release
- Repeat 4–6 times per session

TONGUE TIE

- Use a clean finger to lift the tongue up and back
- Exposing the diamond-shaped wound under the tongue
- Hold for 1–2 seconds, release
- Repeat 4–6 times per session

i For babies and small children: do stretches when they're calm or sleepy — not mid-feed or mid-cry. Wash your hands first. A little fussiness is expected; it passes in under a minute.

2 Pain, bleeding & what's normal

PAIN

Most patients need little to no pain medication. For adults, **ibuprofen + acetaminophen** as needed is plenty. For children, age-appropriate doses of children's ibuprofen or acetaminophen. See your **Medication Guide** for dosing.

BLEEDING

A few drops of blood for the first hour is normal. If bleeding restarts, apply gentle pressure with a clean damp gauze for 5–10 minutes.

THE WHITE OR YELLOW PATCH

Within a day or two, a white, yellow, or gray patch will form at the release site. **This is normal healing tissue — it is not pus or infection.** It gradually shrinks and disappears over 1–2 weeks. Many parents are alarmed by this; nothing to worry about.

3 Eating & drinking

GOOD CHOICES

- ✓ Cool or room-temperature foods
- ✓ Yogurt, pudding, applesauce
- ✓ Smoothies (small sips, no straw today)
- ✓ Soft pasta, eggs, mashed potatoes
- ✓ Normal breastfeeding/bottle-feeding for infants

AVOID FOR A FEW DAYS

- ✗ Hot foods or drinks
- ✗ Spicy, salty, or acidic foods (citrus, tomato)
- ✗ Crunchy, hard foods
- ✗ Straws for 24 hours

4 What's normal vs. what's not

NORMAL (EXPECTED)

- ✓ White, yellow, or gray patch at the site for 1–2 weeks
- ✓ Mild soreness that fades over a few days
- ✓ Some fussiness in children during stretches
- ✓ Small amount of blood-tinged saliva for a few hours
- ✓ Slight swelling of the lip or under the tongue

CALL OUR OFFICE

- ✗ Bleeding that won't stop after 15–20 min of gentle pressure
- ✗ Severe pain not controlled by medication
- ✗ Fever over 101°F
- ✗ Swelling getting worse after day 2
- ✗ Foul taste or pus from the site
- ✗ The released tissue appearing to reattach despite stretches

When to call us

- Bleeding that won't stop after 15–20 min of gentle pressure
- Severe pain not controlled by medication
- Fever over 101°F
- Swelling getting worse after day 2
- Signs of infection: pus, foul smell, spreading redness
- The site looking like it's reattaching despite doing stretches

URGENT — DON'T WAIT

- Difficulty breathing or swallowing
- Rapidly spreading swelling to your neck or under the tongue

Call our office right away for the on-call provider. If you truly cannot breathe or swallow, call 911.